

Phase 3: Validate With 20 Conversations

Document type: founder-led customer discovery execution guide.

Status: internal working document. Use for controlled discovery only. Do not use as public marketing copy without founder, product, security, and counsel review.

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Required boundary: GCCS is a No-CUI / compliance management MVP. Discovery conversations must not ask prospects to share real CUI, classified information, ITAR/export-controlled data, credentials, payroll records, SSNs, health data, sensitive incident details, or customer documents.

Phase Goal

Validate whether small government contractors and their advisors have a painful, repeated readiness workflow that GCCS can solve before spending money on ads, broad content, sponsorships, or paid lead generation.

The goal is not to sell first. The goal is to learn:

1. Which workflow is painful enough to pay for.
2. Who owns the workflow today.
3. What tool or spreadsheet breaks first.
4. What proof buyers are asked to provide.
5. Whether a No-CUI readiness workflow is acceptable for an MVP pilot.
6. What price range creates a real buying signal.
7. Which channel can refer the first paid pilot.

Critique And Failure Risks

- Buying ads now would likely waste budget because the offer is still unvalidated. Ads amplify a message; they do not discover the message.
- Interviewing only founders creates confirmation bias. Advisors, MSPs, accountants, proposal consultants, and APEX counselors see repeated workflow failures across many contractors.
- Asking for product feedback too early will produce feature requests, not buying signals. The conversation must focus on current workflow pain, proof requests, lost evidence, and willingness to pilot one narrow workflow.

Phase 3 Exit Criteria

Phase 3 is complete only when all of these are true:

- 20 completed conversations are logged.
- At least 12 conversations are with small GovCon founders, operators, contracts leads, security leads, or people directly advising them.
- At least 5 conversations come from advisor/referral channels.
- At least 10 participants identify the same painful workflow in similar language.
- At least 5 participants agree to a follow-up demo or pilot discussion.
- At least 2 participants show credible paid-pilot intent.
- At least 1 participant is qualified for the Phase 1 paid pilot offer.

- The top painful workflow is documented in the buyer's words.

Conversation Mix

Use this mix for the first 20 conversations.

Segment	Target completed conversations	Why this segment matters
Local APEX Accelerator counselors	3	They see many early and growth-stage contractors and can identify readiness, registration, certification, and opportunity-research pain patterns.
Small GovCon founders/operators	7	They are the economic buyers or daily owners of the workflow.
MSPs serving defense contractors	3	They see CMMC, NIST 800-171, Microsoft 365, evidence, and support-ticket pain across multiple clients.
Fractional compliance consultants	2	They see gaps between policies, tasks, evidence, and owner accountability.
GovCon accountants/bookkeepers	2	They see contract, audit, payroll/timekeeping, DCAA, billing, and proof-retention friction.
Proposal consultants	2	They see pre-award compliance promises, representations, certifications, and proposal-response pressure.
Small prime/subcontractor networks	1	They can validate whether primes ask small subcontractors for proof and whether referral channels exist.

If a segment is producing weak learning, do not keep forcing it. Replace weak channels with the segment producing the clearest repeated pain.

Direct Discovery Sources And Contact Information

Use official directories and public business contact channels first. Do not scrape private emails, buy lists, or send mass messages.

Row 1

Segment

Local APEX Accelerator counselors

Primary contact source

SBA Federal Contracting Assistance (<https://www.sba.gov/local-assistance/federal-contracting-assistance>) and National APEX Accelerator Alliance location directory (<https://www.napex.us/location/>)

Public contact details or lookup path

SBA states APEX Accelerators help businesses with contracting readiness, registration, certification eligibility, and past opportunity research. Use the APEX directory to find the counselor serving your state or region.

What to ask for

Ask for a 20-minute market-learning call and referrals to contractors struggling with readiness tracking.

Row 2

Segment

SBA district or federal contracting offices

Primary contact source

SBA District Offices (<https://www.sba.gov/about-sba/sba-locations/sba-district-offices>) and SBA Office of Government Contracting (<https://www.sba.gov/about-sba/sba-locations/headquarters-offices/office-government-contracting>)

Public contact details or lookup path

SBA main contact shown on the SBA site: 800-827-5722. Office of Government Contracting address: 409 3rd St. SW, Suite 8800, Washington, DC 20416.

What to ask for

Ask which local events, office hours, or counselors are best for small GovCon workflow discovery.

Row 3

Segment

Small GovCon founders

Primary contact source

SBA Small Business Search (<https://search.certifications.sba.gov/>), SAM.gov Entity Information (<https://sam.gov/entity-information>), USAspending keyword search (https://www.usaspending.gov/keyword_search), GSA eLibrary (<https://www.gsaelibrary.gsa.gov/>)

Public contact details or lookup path

Use company websites, public contact forms, LinkedIn company pages, and founder/operator LinkedIn profiles.

What to ask for

Ask founders how they track compliance tasks, proof, contract clauses, and evidence today.

Row 4

Segment

Prime/subcontractor targets

Primary contact source

SBA Directory of Federal Government Prime Contractors with Subcontracting Plans (<https://www.sba.gov/document/support-directory-federal-government-prime-contractors-subcontracting-plans>)

Public contact details or lookup path

SBA says this directory identifies prime contractors with subcontracting requirements and recommends using it to research prime contractor subcontractor processes.

What to ask for

Ask primes what proof they request from small subcontractors and where subcontractors fail.

Row 5

Segment

MSPs serving defense contractors

Primary contact source

The Cyber AB Marketplace (<https://cyberab.org/Catalog>), Project Spectrum (<https://www.projectspectrum.io/>), DoD/OSBP Cybersecurity Resources (<https://business.defense.gov/Programs/Cyber-Security-Resources/>)

Public contact details or lookup path

Project Spectrum contact: support@projectspectrum.io. DoD/OSBP cybersecurity page lists 571.372.6191 and osd.business.defense@mail.mil for questions.

What to ask for

Ask MSPs which readiness/evidence tasks clients cannot maintain after initial setup.

Row 6

Segment

Fractional compliance consultants

Primary contact source

The Cyber AB Marketplace (<https://cyberab.org/Catalog>), LinkedIn searches, Project Spectrum ecosystem events

Public contact details or lookup path

Search Cyber AB for RPs/RPOs and LinkedIn for fractional CMMC, NIST 800-171 consultant, GovCon compliance consultant, and DFARS compliance consultant.

What to ask for

Ask which recurring compliance workflow creates the most avoidable support work.

Row 7

Segment

GovCon accountants/bookkeepers

Primary contact source

AICPA GAQC directory (<https://www.aicpa-cima.com/about/download/gaqc-membership-directory-listed-by-state>), local CPA directories, GovCon accounting firm sites

Public contact details or lookup path

Public example contacts found during source verification: Cherry Bekaert GovCon team 800 . 279 . 9469; Wendroff DCAA CPA services 703 - 553 - 1099; Diener & Associates GovCon consulting 703 . 386 . 7864. Treat examples as discovery targets, not endorsements.

What to ask for

Ask what compliance evidence or contract proof clients lose track of around accounting, billing, timekeeping, audits, and contract administration.

Row 8

Segment

Proposal consultants

Primary contact source

APMP (<https://www.apmp.org/>) and APMP Consultants Directory reference (<https://winningthebusiness.com/apmp-launches-new-consultants-directory/>)

Public contact details or lookup path

APMP is the proposal-management professional association. Use APMP chapters, consultant listings, public contact forms, and LinkedIn.

What to ask for

Ask what compliance claims, representations, certifications, and proof requests appear during proposal work.

Row 9

Segment

Small prime/subcontractor networks

Primary contact source

NDIA Small Business Division (<https://www.ndia.org/divisions/small-business>), SAME (<https://www.same.org/>), NSBGCA (<https://www.nsbga.org/>), NVSBC (<https://nvsbc.org/>)

Public contact details or lookup path

NDIA Small Business contact: Andrew Peters, 703 - 247 - 2572, apeters@NDIA.org; Kimberly Williams, 703 - 247 - 2578, kwilliams@NDIA.org. NSBGCA: INFO@NSBGCA.ORG, 202 . 286 . 0557. NVSBC general address is listed publicly on its site; use the contact page for current routing.

What to ask for

Ask for event access, warm introductions, and patterns they see in small contractor readiness.

LinkedIn Search Plan

Run these searches manually and record every target in the tracker before outreach.

Search phrase	Best filters	Target person
government contractor	United States, 1-50 employees, Founder/Owner/President/COO	Small GovCon founder or operator.
CMMC	United States, small business, defense, cybersecurity	Security lead, MSP, compliance consultant, RPO/RP.
DoD subcontractor	United States, aerospace, defense, manufacturing, IT services	Subcontractor founder or operations lead.

Search phrase	Best filters	Target person
8(a)	United States, founder, president, CEO, contracts	Socioeconomic-program contractor owner.
SDVOSB	United States, veteran-owned, federal contractor	Veteran-owned contractor founder.
WOSB	United States, woman-owned, federal contractor	Woman-owned contractor founder.
GovCon accountant	United States, DCAA, FAR, CAS, outsourced accounting	Accountant or fractional CFO serving contractors.
government proposal consultant	United States, APMP, capture, proposal manager	Proposal consultant or capture advisor.
NIST 800-171 consultant	United States, CMMC, DFARS, MSP	Compliance consultant or MSP.

Outreach Rules

- Do not say you are looking for customers in the first message.
- Do not ask them to upload, share, or send contract documents.
- Do not claim GCCS handles CUI.
- Do not pitch certification, legal advice, accounting advice, or assessment outcomes.
- Do not use automated bulk outreach until the manual message converts.
- Ask for 20 minutes, not 45 or 60.
- Make the ask specific: workflow pain, not product feedback.

Outreach Message Templates

APEX Counselor

Subject: Learning from small contractor readiness workflows

Hi <Name>,

I am building GCCS, a No-CUI compliance-management workflow tool for small government contractors. I am not asking you to evaluate the product or refer clients into a sale.

I am trying to understand where small contractors lose track of readiness tasks, evidence, clause obligations, and proof requests. Since APEX works directly with businesses on contracting readiness, registration, certification eligibility, and opportunity research, your perspective would be useful.

Would you be open to a 20-minute market-learning call? I am specifically trying to learn what spreadsheet or manual workflow breaks first.

Thank you, <Your Name>

Founder Or Operator

Subject: Quick question on GovCon readiness tracking

Hi <Name>,

I am interviewing small government contractors to understand how readiness tasks, contract obligations, and evidence are tracked today.

This is not a request for contract documents, CUI, or sensitive information. I am only trying to understand the workflow: spreadsheets, shared folders, email, task ownership, and proof requests.

Would you be open to a 20-minute call? The main question is: where does the current tracking process break first?

Thank you, <Your Name>

MSP Or Compliance Consultant

Subject: Learning where GovCon clients lose compliance evidence

Hi <Name>,

I am doing customer discovery for GCCS, a No-CUI readiness workflow tool for small government contractors. I am trying to understand the recurring operational problems advisors see across clients: task ownership, evidence metadata, obligation tracking, report prep, and audit trail gaps.

Would you be open to a 20-minute call? I am not asking for client names or sensitive details. I am trying to learn which workflow repeatedly creates support burden.

Thank you, <Your Name>

Accountant, Bookkeeper, Or Fractional CFO

Subject: GovCon client proof and tracking workflow question

Hi <Name>,

I am interviewing advisors who support small government contractors. I am trying to understand what proof, records, evidence, and contract-readiness tracking clients lose track of before audits, billing questions, renewals, or prime requests.

No client names or sensitive data needed. Would you be open to a 20-minute call focused only on workflow pain?

Thank you, <Your Name>

Proposal Consultant

Subject: Proposal-stage compliance proof question

Hi <Name>,

I am researching where small GovCon teams struggle to connect proposal commitments, contract obligations, and later proof. I am not asking for proposal documents or client details.

Would you be open to a 20-minute call about the compliance-tracking workflows that break before, during, or after proposal submission?

Thank you, <Your Name>

Discovery Call Structure

Use this structure for every call so the answers can be compared.

Time	Segment	What to do
0-2 min	Boundary	State that the call is discovery only, not a sales call, and that no CUI or sensitive data should be shared.
2-5 min	Context	Ask about their role, company type, contract stage, and whether they are founder, advisor, MSP, accountant, or consultant.
5-18 min	Workflow discovery	Ask the core questions below. Let them describe the workflow before showing or describing GCCS.
18-22 min	Pain ranking	Ask which problem is most painful, most frequent, and most expensive to ignore.
22-26 min	Willingness to pay	Ask what would make a narrow readiness workflow worth \$99-\$499/month or a \$750 guided pilot.
26-29 min	Referrals	Ask who else sees this problem repeatedly.
29-30 min	Close	Ask whether they are willing to see a short demo or introduce one relevant person.

Required Questions

Ask these verbatim unless the conversation naturally covers them.

1. Where do you track compliance tasks today?
2. What evidence do you lose track of?
3. Who asks you for proof?
4. What spreadsheet breaks first?
5. What would make this worth \$99-\$499/month?
6. What would make you refuse to use it?
7. Would you pilot this with one contract/program using only synthetic, redacted, or non-sensitive data?

Additional Segment-Specific Questions

APEX Counselors

- What readiness issue appears before a contractor is ready for opportunities?
- Which contractors are too early for GCCS?
- Which contractors are advanced enough to care about evidence and obligation tracking?
- Do counselors see more pain around registration, certifications, contracts, cybersecurity, accounting, or proof requests?
- What local events or cohorts would be appropriate for founder-led discovery?

Small GovCon Founders

- Who owns contract compliance tracking in your company?
- What happens when a prime, agency, auditor, or advisor asks for proof?
- How many spreadsheets, folders, or systems are involved?
- What would stop you from running a No-CUI pilot?
- Would you pay for guided setup if it saved your team from rebuilding the readiness tracker manually?

MSPs

- Which client tasks are not technical but still create support burden?
- What evidence do clients fail to maintain after Microsoft 365, endpoint, or policy setup?
- Do clients understand the difference between FCI, CUI, and general compliance metadata?
- Would a No-CUI workflow help you organize client follow-through without storing sensitive content?

Compliance Consultants

- Where do clients lose the thread between requirements, owners, evidence, and status?
- What is usually missing when a readiness review starts?
- Which artifacts do clients think they have but cannot produce quickly?
- Would you refer clients into a narrow readiness workflow if it reduced manual coordination?

Accountants And Bookkeepers

- What contract or audit-support evidence do clients misplace?
- Where do timekeeping, billing, indirect rates, or DCAA-related workflows create operational tracking pain?

- Do clients confuse accounting compliance with general contract-readiness tracking?
- What would make you trust or reject a tool in this workflow?

Proposal Consultants

- Which compliance promises or representations create downstream tracking problems?
- Do small contractors know how they will prove a claim after award?
- What parts of the proposal-to-contract handoff are undocumented?
- Would a readiness report or obligation workflow help before submission, after award, or both?

Networks And Associations

- Which event formats produce real conversations with small contractors?
- Which members repeatedly ask about CMMC, evidence, contract-readiness, or subcontractor proof?
- Would the network host a learning session if it is explicitly No-CUI and non-legal-advice?
- Who are the three members most likely to give direct feedback?

What To Capture After Every Call

Use phase-3-discovery-tracker.csv (./phase-3-discovery-tracker.csv) or copy these fields into your CRM.

Field	Required value
Date	Call date.
Segment	APEX, founder, MSP, compliance consultant, accountant/bookkeeper, proposal consultant, network.
Contact source	Directory, LinkedIn, referral, event, website, partner.
Contact name	Person spoken with.
Organization	Company or organization.
Role	Founder, contracts lead, security lead, counselor, advisor, etc.
Current workflow	Spreadsheet, email, folder, GRC tool, PSA, ticketing, ERP, none.
Pain quote	Exact buyer/advisor words.
Lost evidence	Evidence or proof they lose track of.
Proof requester	Prime, agency, auditor, internal owner, MSP, accountant, proposal team.
Broken spreadsheet	The specific spreadsheet or tracker that fails first.
Price reaction	Reaction to \$99-\$499/month and/or \$750 pilot.
Refusal trigger	What would make them refuse.
No-CUI acceptance	Yes, no, unclear.
Pilot interest	No, demo only, maybe, strong, paid intent.
Referral offered	Names or channels offered.
Next action	Demo, follow-up, intro, no follow-up.

Scoring Rules

Score each completed conversation from 0 to 3.

Score	Meaning	Evidence
0	No fit	They do not recognize the workflow pain, cannot use No-CUI, or want unrelated services.
1	Weak pain	They understand the category but have no urgency, budget, or owner.
2	Real pain	They can describe a recurring manual workflow and a named owner or proof requester.
3	Pilot signal	They describe painful workflow, accept No-CUI, react reasonably to price, and agree to demo, referral, or pilot discussion.

Move to Phase 4 only if the average score across the final 10 conversations is at least 2.0 and at least 2 conversations score 3.

Conversation Pattern Analysis

After 20 calls, write a one-page summary using this structure:

1. Most repeated painful workflow.
2. Buyer language used to describe the pain.
3. Current workaround.
4. Who owns the problem.
5. Who asks for proof.
6. What evidence is lost or hard to assemble.
7. No-CUI acceptance rate.
8. Price reaction.
9. Top refusal reasons.
10. Best referral channel.
11. Recommended Phase 4 offer adjustment.

Decision Rules

Signal	Action
Founders repeatedly mention lost evidence and proof requests	Keep offer focused on obligation/evidence workflow and readiness reports.
Advisors repeatedly mention client follow-through burden	Build advisor/referral motion before ads.
Prospects reject No-CUI	Do not force the sale. Route to future CUI-ready roadmap only if appropriate.
Buyers want certification guarantees	Disqualify. GCCS must not claim certification, assessor, legal, or government determinations.
Price resistance is high but pain is real	Keep paid pilot but narrow scope, not price first.
No one accepts a follow-up demo	Rework positioning before building more sales assets.
At least 2 prospects show paid pilot intent	Move to Phase 4: guided demo and pilot close.

No-CUI Discovery Script

Use this at the start of each call:

Before we get into workflow details, please do not share real CUI, classified information, ITAR/export-controlled data, credentials, payroll records, SSNs, health data, incident

details, or contract documents. I only want to discuss the workflow at a non-sensitive level: how tasks, owners, evidence metadata, and proof requests are tracked. GCCS is currently a No-CUI compliance-management MVP, not legal advice, not certification, and not an assessor decision.

Weekly Execution Plan

Week	Target
Week 1	Build list of 80 targets: 15 APEX/SBA/network, 30 founders/operators, 15 MSP/compliance, 10 accountants, 10 proposal consultants. Send 30 manual messages. Book 6 calls.
Week 2	Complete 8-10 calls. Ask every participant for 1 referral. Update pain-language notes after every call.
Week 3	Complete remaining calls. Prioritize segments producing score-2 and score-3 conversations. Run 2 demos only if the discovery signal is strong.
Week 4	Synthesize findings. Adjust the Phase 1 offer, Phase 2 deck/demo, and pilot scope. Identify first paid pilot candidate.

Hidden Risks

- Public directory contact information changes. Verify phone numbers, email addresses, and contact pages before outreach.
- APEX counselors may not be able to promote a private vendor. Ask for market learning, not endorsement.
- Advisors may protect client confidentiality. Do not ask for client names or documents.
- Cyber AB Marketplace listings are useful for ecosystem discovery, but RPO/RP status is not a blanket endorsement of an advisor.
- GovCon accounting conversations can drift into accounting advice. Keep discovery focused on workflow pain and proof tracking.
- Proposal consultants may push toward proposal automation. GCCS should not reposition around proposal automation unless the evidence from 20 calls clearly supports it.
- High interest without willingness to schedule a demo or discuss a paid pilot is not validation.
- No-CUI refusal is a product-scope signal, not a sales objection to overcome during MVP discovery.

Source Notes

- SBA states APEX Accelerators provide technical assistance to businesses selling to federal, state, and local governments and can help determine contracting readiness, registration, certification eligibility, and research past opportunities: SBA Federal Contracting Assistance (<https://www.sba.gov/local-assistance/federal-contracting-assistance>).
- SBA maintains district office and government contracting resources: SBA District Offices (<https://www.sba.gov/about-sba/sba-locations/sba-district-offices>), Office of Government Contracting (<https://www.sba.gov/about-sba/sba-locations/headquarters-offices/office-government-contracting>).
- SBA Small Business Search, SAM.gov, USAspending, GSA eLibrary, and SBA's prime contractor subcontracting-plan directory are discovery sources for identifying contractor and prime/subcontractor ecosystems.
- DoD/OSBP identifies Project Spectrum as a cybersecurity education, awareness, and compliance resource for small and medium-sized businesses: DoD/OSBP Cybersecurity Resources (<https://business.defense.gov/Programs/Cyber-Security-Resources/>) and CMMC 2.0 Resources (<https://business.defense.gov/Programs/Cyber-Security-Resources/CMMC-20/>).

- NDIA, SAME, NSBGCA, NVSBC, APMP, and AICPA GAQC are network or professional-association sources for advisor and contractor discovery. Use them for learning and introductions, not implied endorsement.